

A Register of Object and Argument

What the objects are, what Culin says they show, and what the claim actually rests on — part by part.

Culin's three pages, before any object · part The introduction

WHAT THE OBJECTS ARE

None. It is the only part of the book with no catalogue number in it.

WHAT CULIN SAYS THEY SHOW

That chess and playing-cards both descend from the divinatory use of the arrow; that the basis of the divinatory systems is the classification of all things by the Four Directions; and that “survivals of these magical processes constitute our present games.”

WHAT THE CLAIM RESTS ON

On Cushing's suggestion, on the universality of four-fold classification among the peoples Culin knew about, and on the observation that the commonest instrument for determining a number is not a die but a set of flat-and-round staves — which is true, and is the best single sentence in the introduction.

HOW TO READ IT

Read it first and read it twice. Everything in the catalogue is arranged to support it, so knowing what the arrangement is for is the difference between reading a catalogue and reading an argument.

Chess and the games of the board — entries 45 to 60 · part One

WHAT THE OBJECTS ARE

Sixteen sets and boards: Chaturanga reconstructed, the Burmese, Maldivian, Malay, Moroccan and English games, Chinese, Korean and Japanese chess, go and its relatives, fox-and-geese in Japan, Malaya and the United States, and a Zuni board game of stone warriors. Almost all are physical objects Culin held, with dimensions and museum numbers.

WHAT CULIN SAYS THEY SHOW

That the chessboard descends from a diagram used to classify things by the Four Directions, and that the moves of the pieces are survivals of the throws by which the classification was determined.

WHAT THE CLAIM RESTS ON

On the four-fold symmetry of the board and on Chaturanga, the four-handed dice chess described in the Bhavishya Purana, in which the pieces genuinely do move by the throw of a die. Chaturanga is the strongest evidence he has for the whole book, and he knows it — it is entry 45, the first thing in this volume.

HOW TO READ IT

Take the descriptions as reliable and the descent as an open question. The modern consensus derives chess from Chaturanga too, but as a game from a game, not from divination. Culin's extra step is the one to watch.

The arrows, the lots and the gambling-sticks — entries 61 to 76 · part Two

WHAT THE OBJECTS ARE

A Korean ceremonial quiver, Chinese and Japanese divining splints, lot answers from a temple, the tallies of a Chinese lottery, arrows from the McCloud River Indians, and a large series of carved Alaskan gambling sticks. The gambling-stick entry is the longest in the volume.

WHAT CULIN SAYS THEY SHOW

That these are the missing link: implements that are still arrows, still used to divine, and already used to gamble. If the chain holds anywhere it holds here.

WHAT THE CLAIM RESTS ON

On the objects genuinely being both — the divining splints of a Chinese temple are drawn at random to answer a question, and the same shop sells the gambler's lots. That much is observation. The step to chess and cards is analogy.

HOW TO READ IT

This is the part to read slowly. It is also the part where Culin's own reporting is most valuable independent of what he concludes: the Alaskan gambling sticks were being collected and lost fast, and his description of sixty-two of them in a leather pouch is a record nobody else made.

The cards of Asia — entries 77 to 84 · part Three

WHAT THE OBJECTS ARE

Korean htou-tjyen, Chinese packs from Kiu Kiang and Kwangtung, Japanese hana-garuta, Indian ganjifa, Persian ganjifeh, and a pack from Siam.

WHAT CULIN SAYS THEY SHOW

That the Korean pack is the oldest surviving form and the ancestor of the rest, because it is the one that still looks like a bundle of arrows.

WHAT THE CLAIM RESTS ON

On the shape of the Korean cards — long narrow oiled-paper strips with a device at one end — and on the eight suits corresponding to the Eight Directions. The resemblance is real. Whether resemblance is descent is the question the whole book turns on.

HOW TO READ IT

Culin argued this most fully in *Korean Games* three years earlier and here he assumes it. If the argument matters to you, read that chapter beside this one; the two make a pair.

The tarots, and the cards of Europe and America — entries 85 to 120 · part Four

WHAT THE OBJECTS ARE

Thirty-six packs: Italian tarocchi from Milan, Bologna, Florence and Naples, the Tarocchi di Mantegna, minchiate, French and German tarots, Spanish naipes, Swiss, Danish, Swedish, Russian and Austrian packs, an Apache pack, one from Celebes, and a run of American novelty decks ending with a souvenir of the Chicago fair.

WHAT CULIN SAYS THEY SHOW

Very little, and that is the point of the part. Culin mostly stops arguing here and simply describes.

WHAT THE CLAIM RESTS ON

Nothing much — these are catalogue entries in the ordinary sense.

HOW TO READ IT

Read it as what it is: a snapshot of what one collector could gather of the world's playing-cards in the early 1890s, including packs whose makers are now the only record of their firms. The Confederate States pack and the 1863 Union generals pack are here because a museum in Washington had them in 1896, which is its own kind of document.